In an interview to a magazine, he added, ‘Making people aware that they needed to benchmark themselves against the global best; the fact that they needed to re-look at the way they conducted their business; the fact that they needed to be more concerned about their customers’ were the steps needed to be adopted to survive in a liberalized framework.

While he acknowledged that the Tata brand was a ‘household name’ and enjoyed a ‘tremendous brand advantage’, Ratan said that he desired to ‘see the Tatas’ become a ‘highly respected brand’. To achieve it, he advised companies to focus on consistently producing items of high quality. This had to be accompanied by a constant attempt to innovate and improve ‘products so that they are at the leading edge, rather than followers of other products’.

He asked the operating companies to ‘make moves, be more active, be more pro-active to meet the challenges’ that stood before the Tata Group, instead of simply letting the ‘events overtake them’. Ratan added that the group’s biggest concern ‘ought to be the interface with our customers’. He reminded the group companies: ‘We should be treating the customer in the same way that we would want to be treated as customers.’

To keep the companies focused on this imperative, he incorporated ‘customer focus’ as one of the key components of the TBEM and assigned it the highest percentage points or a total of 200 points (20 per cent) or the maximum for any category, to assess the performance of companies. Ratan wanted to make the Tata Group ‘an aggregation of individually highly-driven and highly motivated companies working together as a group to be India’s largest and most trusted group, the most respected and yet be seen as being aggressive and above all customer-oriented and customer-friendly’.

As Ratan said, in the ‘coming century’, ‘the refocused Tata Group’ should act ‘as one’ with each company ‘having its own autonomy and having its own independence’. He added: ‘…we are much more aggressive than we have been … we are much more market oriented than we have been and we [have] in fact become, instead of being looked at as a sleeping giant …a rather aggressive and responsive Group that acts as one.’

By the end of 2001, Ratan had completely overhauled the Tata Group and its companies. The impact was enormous. Ratan’s era would be most remembered the way he ‘repurposed the group’, says Bhaskar Bhat. ‘He adopted a group approach and gave it a new meaning and cohered the various companies through the process of business excellence.’